

The Milkmaid and Her Pail

A young milkmaid named Mira balanced a pail of fresh milk on her head as she walked toward the market. The morning was cool, and the road was quiet except for birds in the hedges. Mira had been asked to sell the milk carefully and bring home the money. She knew the task was simple, yet it felt important; every drop in the pail was worth something to her family.

As she walked, Mira began to imagine what the money might become. "I will sell the milk and buy a basket of eggs," she thought. "The eggs will hatch into chickens. The chickens will lay more eggs, and I will sell those too." Her steps grew lighter. She pictured a small coop, then a flock, then enough money to buy a fine new dress for the spring festival.

The dream grew larger with every turn in the road. She imagined arriving at the festival in her new dress while the other young people admired it. She imagined someone making a foolish boast, and she imagined herself tossing her head proudly to show that she did not care. Without thinking, Mira gave her head a quick, proud shake.

The pail slipped. Milk spilled down her hair, across her dress, and into the dust of the road. For a moment Mira stood still, watching the white stream disappear into the earth. The eggs, chickens, flock, and festival dress vanished with it. She wanted to cry, but she also knew that none of those things had ever belonged to her. They had been plans built on a pail she had not yet delivered.

Mira returned home and told the truth. Her family was disappointed, but they helped her clean the pail and begin again the next day. This time she walked with one hand steadying the milk. She still had hopes, but she kept them gentle until her work was complete. Years later, she became known in the market as a careful trader. She would smile when young sellers spoke of grand profits and say, "Dream of tomorrow, but keep hold of what you carry today."